

3 adults + 2 kids (5 & 7) · free-first · toilets at every main stop

The Nairn Grand Loop — up the wild west, home down the A9

One night in **Nairn (IV12 5DE)**: check-in **6 PM Sat 30 May**, early check-out **~8:45 AM Sun 31 May 2026** to free the whole of Sunday. Leave Glasgow **6 AM Saturday**; home Sunday evening. Two different routes so no view repeats, every stop chosen for **old heritage and the best scenery**: **Saturday (7 stops)** = Loch Lomond, Glencoe, the **Glenfinnan "Harry Potter" viaduct**, Jacobite Fort William, Loch Ness & Urquhart Castle, Clava Cairns/Culloden; **Sunday (7 stops)** = the Cairngorms, the open-air Highland Folk Museum, Ruthven Barracks, Killiecrankie, Pitlochry & Dunkeld Cathedral. **Every stop below is free to enter**, flat and kid-friendly, with its significance, Google-Maps postcode, arrival time and stay length for easy route-planning.

Grand loop ≈ 395 mi · one car

Sat: 6 AM → Nairn 6 PM

Sun: out ~9 AM → home ~7:45 PM



Glenfinnan viaduct (train if running — check live)

Est. spend ≈ £270–290 (excl. hotel)

FREE-FIRST · GRAND LOOP · PDF-READY

How to read this plan

The route *is* the holiday. Two big driving days, each a string of free, flat, toilet-equipped stops chosen for **old heritage + the best scenic views**. **Saturday** takes the long scenic west road to Nairn; **Sunday**, after an early checkout, ambles home down the A9. The two tables give you everything to optimise on Google Maps: **significance · postcode · arrive · drive · stay · toilets · cost**. Times are tentative — trim a stop or two if the kids flag (I flag the best ones to drop).

Tag key: 🏰 heritage / history · 🌄 scenic view · 👨‍👩‍👧‍👦 great for the kids · 🚂 the railway · 🍷 food stop.

⚠️ **Steam train not confirmed.** As of late-May 2026 West Coast Railways had **delayed the Jacobite season with no published start date** (carriage safety retrofit). Don't bank on a steam crossing — **check live tonight** at westcoastrailways.co.uk. Backup: the viaduct is free & stunning anyway, and ordinary **ScotRail Fort William→Mallaig** trains cross it daily — look up a time at scotrail.co.uk.

The loop at a glance

blue = Saturday up · orange = Sunday home



● Saturday — up the west (1–7) ● Sunday — home down the A9 (A–G) ● Nairn (hotel base) ● Glasgow

Click any pin for the same detail as the tables below. Scroll to zoom (click map first).

Saturday 30 May — Glasgow → Nairn up the west · ≈218 mi · depart 6:00 AM

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
1	Loch Lomond — Luss village  The 'bonnie banks' of Britain's largest loch by surface area, framed by Ben Lomond. Luss is a preserved 18th–19th-century slate-quarry village of rose-clad cottages; its lochside churchyard (St Kessog's) sits on a 7th-century Christian site and holds Norse 'hogback' gravestones — a quiet heritage gem the tour buses skip.	G83 8NN Luss, Alexandria G83 8NN	6:50 +50 min · 25 mi	20 min	Yes	Parking ~£5
2	Glencoe — Three Sisters & Folk Museum  Scotland's most cinematic glen — three glacier-carved spurs of Bidean nam Bian, scene of the 1692 Massacre of Glencoe and a backdrop in Skyfall and the Harry Potter films. The viewpoint is roadside (no walk); in the village the donation-funded Glencoe Folk Museum occupies 18th-century heather-thatched cottages, and the NTS Visitor Centre (PH49 4HX) tells the massacre story with café & toilets.	PH49 4HX Three Sisters Viewpoint, A82, Glencoe PH49 4HX	8:25 +1h15 · 45 mi	30 min	Yes	Free (parking ~£4)
3	Glenfinnan Viaduct & Monument —  the Harry Potter bridge  The 21-arch 'Hogwarts Express' viaduct (1901, an early mass-concrete marvel) curving above Loch Shiel. At its foot the Glenfinnan Monument marks the exact spot where Bonnie Prince Charlie raised his standard to launch the 1745 Jacobite rising. Flat tarmac path 5–10 min to stand UNDER the arches — pushchair-friendly, no climb.	PH37 4LT Glenfinnan Visitor Centre, Glenfinnan PH37 4LT · info	10:10 +1h15 · 50 mi	75 min	Yes	Parking £3.50

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
4	Fort William — West Highland Museum, Old Inverlochy Castle & lunch  The 'Outdoor Capital of the UK' at the foot of Ben Nevis, Britain's highest mountain. The FREE West Highland Museum is a Jacobite treasure-house — including the famous anamorphic 'secret portrait' of Prince Charlie. On the town's edge, FREE Old Inverlochy Castle is a near-intact 13th-century courtyard fortress that saw two battles. Best lunch & last big fuel before the remote Loch Ness road.	PH33 6AJ West Highland Museum, Cameron Square, Fort William PH33 6AJ · info	11:55 +30 min · 17 mi	70 min	Yes	Free (lunch)
5	Fort Augustus — Caledonian Canal locks  A staircase of five locks lifting boats 13m where Thomas Telford's Caledonian Canal (opened 1822) meets the southern tip of Loch Ness — boats rising, the swing-bridge turning, beside the site of the old Hanoverian fort that named the village. Cafés, ice cream, toilets; superb kid-watching.	PH32 4BD Fort Augustus PH32 4BD · info	13:55 +50 min · 33 mi	45 min	Yes	Free
6	Loch Ness — Urquhart Castle  The most famous loch on earth (the UK's largest body of fresh water by volume) and, on a rocky headland, one of Scotland's biggest medieval castles — held and besieged from the 1200s to 1692, its Grant Tower still standing. Free lay-by views; history-loving adults may want to pay in (HES) for the full ruin. Nessie-spotting delights the kids.	IV63 6XJ Urquhart Castle, Drumnadrochit IV63 6XJ	15:10 +30 min · 18 mi	35 min	Yes	Free view / ~£15 in

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
7	Clava Cairns & Culloden Battlefield  Two heritage heavyweights side by side. Clava Cairns: 4,000-year-old Bronze Age passage-graves aligned to the midwinter-solstice sunset, ringed by standing stones (Outlander's 'Craigh na Dun'). Five minutes away, Culloden Moor is where the rising died on 16 April 1746 — walk the clan-grave lines free; the immersive NTS centre (toilets/café) is optional/paid.	IV2 5EU Clava Cairns, Culloden, Inverness IV2 5EU · info	16:30 +45 min · 22 mi	50 min	Yes	Free
★	Nairn — hotel (IV12 5DE)		~17:45 +25 min · 12 mi	Check-in 6 PM · evening on the beach		

Saturday evening in Nairn arrive ~5–6 PM

Check in, drop bags, then a free long-daylight evening (sunset ~9:45 PM):

- **Nairn Central Beach & promenade** — *Marine Rd, Nairn IV12 4EA*. Wide flat sand, play area, toilets, ice cream; bottlenose dolphins sometimes offshore. Free parking. **FREE**
- **Nairn Harbour** — *Harbour St, Nairn IV12 4PH*. Pretty boats, short stroll, crab-watching. **FREE**
- Dinner in town (chip shops, pubs, Indian/Italian on the High St) then back for an early night before the big Sunday.

Sunday 31 May — Nairn → Glasgow home down the A9 · ≈177 mi · early checkout, out

~9:00 AM

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
A	Loch Morlich, Glenmore (Cairngorms)  Britain's highest sandy beach — freshwater, ringed by the Cairngorm massif and the ancient Caledonian pinewoods of Rothiemurchus and Glenmore (red squirrels, crested tits, sometimes free-ranging reindeer). Paddling, stone-skimming and a flat lochshore loop.	PH22 1QU Glenmore, Aviemore PH22 1QU	9:55 +55 min · 38 mi	50 min	Yes	Free (parking ~£4)
B	Highland Folk Museum, Newtonmore  Britain's first open-air museum (1934): walk through Baile Gean, a fully re-created 1700s Highland township of turf houses you can step inside — used as an Outlander season-1 filming set — plus a Victorian schoolroom, a 1930s working farm and costumed interpreters. Playground, café, picnic lawns.	PH20 1AY Highland Folk Museum, Kingussie Rd, Newtonmore PH20 1AY · info	11:10 +25 min · 22 mi	1h40 (lunch)	Yes	Free (donation)
C	Ruthven Barracks, Kingussie  A gaunt 1719 infantry barracks raised by the government to police the Highlands after the 1715 rising — and the very place the Jacobite army rallied after Culloden before scattering, burning it behind them. A floodlit ruin on a glacial mound with huge Spey-valley views; 5-min walk up. 2 min from the Folk Museum.	PH21 1NR Ruthven Barracks, Kingussie PH21 1NR · info	12:55 +5 min · 3 mi	25 min	None*	Free

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
D	House of Bruar & Falls of Bruar (Blair Castle nearby)  Scotland's grandest farm-shop & food hall, with a short flat path to the lower Falls of Bruar — walks first laid out after Robert Burns asked the Duke to clothe the bare braes with trees in 1787. Heritage upgrade 2 min south: Blair Castle, white-turreted seat of the Dukes of Atholl and home to Britain's last private army, the Atholl Highlanders (paid).	PH18 5TW House of Bruar, Blair Atholl PH18 5TW · info	14:05 +45 min · 28 mi	40 min	Yes	Free
E	Killiecrankie — Soldier's Leap  A steep wooded gorge above the River Garry where the first Jacobite rising opened with the Battle of Killiecrankie (1689) — and where a fleeing government soldier made the legendary 18-foot 'Soldier's Leap' across the water. Free NTS site with short flat paths to the viewpoints; blazing autumn-into-summer colour and a cracking story for the kids.	PH16 5LG Killiecrankie, Pitlochry PH16 5LG · info	15:00 +15 min · 9 mi	35 min	Yes	Free

#	Place & why it's worth it	Google Maps (tap postcode)	Arrive	Stay	WC	Cost
F	Pitlochry — Dam, salmon ladder & early dinner  A genteel Victorian spa town that boomed after Queen Victoria toured Perthshire. The free Dam visitor centre has a glass-walled fish ladder where you watch salmon climb; riverside walks and plenty of cafés for an early dinner. Scenic upgrade: Queen's View over Loch Tummel, 7 mi west, named for the Queen's 1866 visit.	PH16 5ND Pitlochry Dam, Armoury Road, Pitlochry PH16 5ND · info	15:45 +10 min · 4 mi	1h20 (dinner)	Yes	Free
G	Dunkeld — Cathedral & The Hermitage  A perfect heritage-and-scenery finale. Dunkeld Cathedral (free) is a part-ruined medieval cathedral on the Tay, burial place of the 'Wolf of Badenoch'. Two miles on, The Hermitage frames Ossian's Hall folly above the roaring Black Linn falls among some of Britain's tallest Douglas firs — flat riverside paths.	PH8 0JR The Hermitage, Dunkeld PH8 0JR · info	17:20 +15 min · 12 mi	55 min	Yes	Parking ~£4 (NTS)
★	Home — Glasgow		~19:45 +1h30 · 62 mi	Relaxed — hours inside your midnight limit		

If the kids fade, the two easiest to drop are **The Hermitage** (last stop) and **House of Bruar** — you'll still get the Cairngorms, Folk Museum and Pitlochry.

What it costs 3 adults + 2 kids, one car, hotel excluded

Money

Fuel — loop $\approx$ 395 mi @ 38 mpg, £1.55/L	$\approx$ £88
All sights free to enter	£0
Parking (Luss, Glencoe, Glenfinnan £3.50, Loch Morlich, Hermitage)	$\approx$ £22
Sat lunch (Fort William) + Sun lunch (Folk Museum / picnic)	$\approx$ £55
Sat supper (Nairn) + Sun dinner (Pitlochry), party of 5	$\approx$ £80–110
Ice creams / coffees / treats	$\approx$ £25
Trip spend excl. hotel	$\approx$ £270–300

Every sight is free — the spend is essentially fuel, parking coins and three meals out.

Toilet & kid logistics

- **Toilets on tap:** Luss, Glencoe Centre, Glenfinnan, Fort William, Fort Augustus, Drumnadrochit (Sat); Loch Morlich, Folk Museum, House of Bruar, Pitlochry, Hermitage (Sun).
- **The one stop with NO toilets:** **Ruthven Barracks** — go at the Highland Folk Museum 5 min before. (Clava Cairns now pairs with Culloden's NTS centre, which has toilets.)
- **No real walking anywhere** — Glenfinnan uses the flat under-the-arches path (skip the 20-min hill); everything else is roadside or a short flat stroll.
- **Fuel discipline:** the A82 is remote — top up in **Fort William** before Loch Ness. A9 home has plenty (Aviemore, Pitlochry).
- Pack a picnic + flasks; cap each stop to the times shown to keep momentum.

Data captured 30 May 2026 from public tourism sources (VisitScotland, NTS, HES, Scottish Canals, High Life Highland, West Coast Railways, ScotRail). Opening hours, prices & the steam-train schedule change — verify before travelling. Distances/drive times approximate; postcodes for sat-nav guidance.